PROOF OF CONCEPT · 3D ANIMATED CINEMATIC SHORT FILM



CRUCIBLE

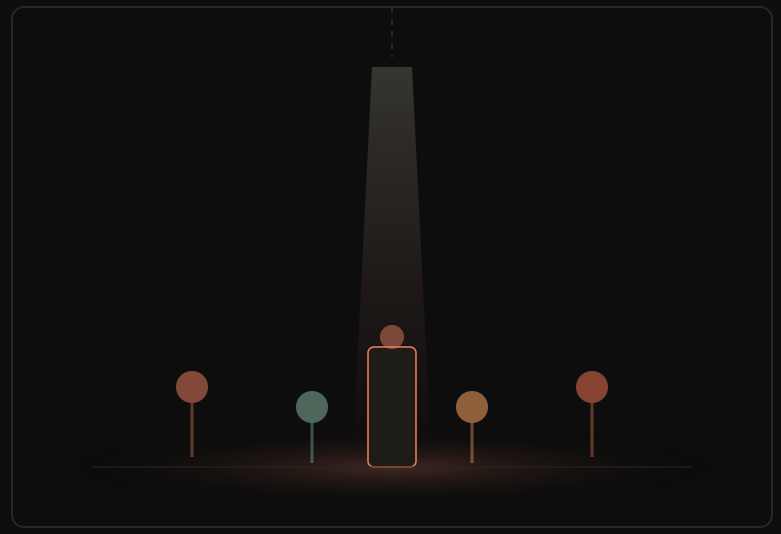
"Inheritance demands everything."

UNREAL ENGINE 5 · SCI-FI PSYCHOLOGICAL THRILLER · 8–12 MIN

EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW

A Lethal Succession Trial Rendered in Real-Time

Four estranged heirs awaken in a sterile white void, forced to survive lethal trials of worth; only one can discard their humanity to claim the architect's empire.



UE5	8–12 min	16–35	4	3
PRODUCTION ENGINE	ESTIMATED RUNTIME	TARGET AGE GROUP	PRINCIPAL CHARACTERS	LETHAL TRIALS

NARRATIVE SYNOPSIS

The Crucible Chamber

Four young adults—Tara, Kwame, James, and Mei—awaken inside a seamless, sterile white enclosure with no doors. Light radiates upward from the center floor.

An omniscient synthesized voice—**The Architect**—forces them into three deadly trials to inherit a sovereign empire. Each trial strips away a human defense: *trust*, *logic*, and *empathy*.

As allies fall one by one, the final survivor discovers that the cruelty she endured was the inheritance itself.

> *"Perception sharp. Sentiment discarded. Resolve absolute. Welcome to the summit, my daughter."*
>
> — THE ARCHITECT

I **ACT I: The Awakening**
Four strangers wake in a sterile white void

1 **TRIAL 1: Sacrifice**
High-voltage biometric circuit synchronization

KWAME ELIMINATED

✧ **The Patriarch's Reveal**
DNA confirmation: all four are half-siblings

2 **TRIAL 2: Exposure**
Neural trauma playback weaponizes abandonment

JAMES ELIMINATED

3 **TRIAL 3: Sleight of Hand**
Single extraction key — betrayal & combat

MEI ELIMINATED

▲ **ASCENSION**
Tara enters the golden penthouse elevator

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

The Four Heirs of the Architect



THE CYNIC / SURVIVOR

TARA

Razor-sharp, guarded. Uses biting sarcasm as armor. Evolves from self-preservation to absolute, remorseless agency.

"I grew up in the same family."



THE STREET PRAGMATIST

KWAME

Street-smart, self-reliant. Trusts nobody. His refusal to yield autonomy causes early elimination in Trial 1.

"Keep your backs together."



THE PERFECTIONIST

JAMES

Hyper-analytical, hyper-vigilant. Seeks paternal approval through logic; shatters under trauma in Trial 2.

"There was never an equation..."

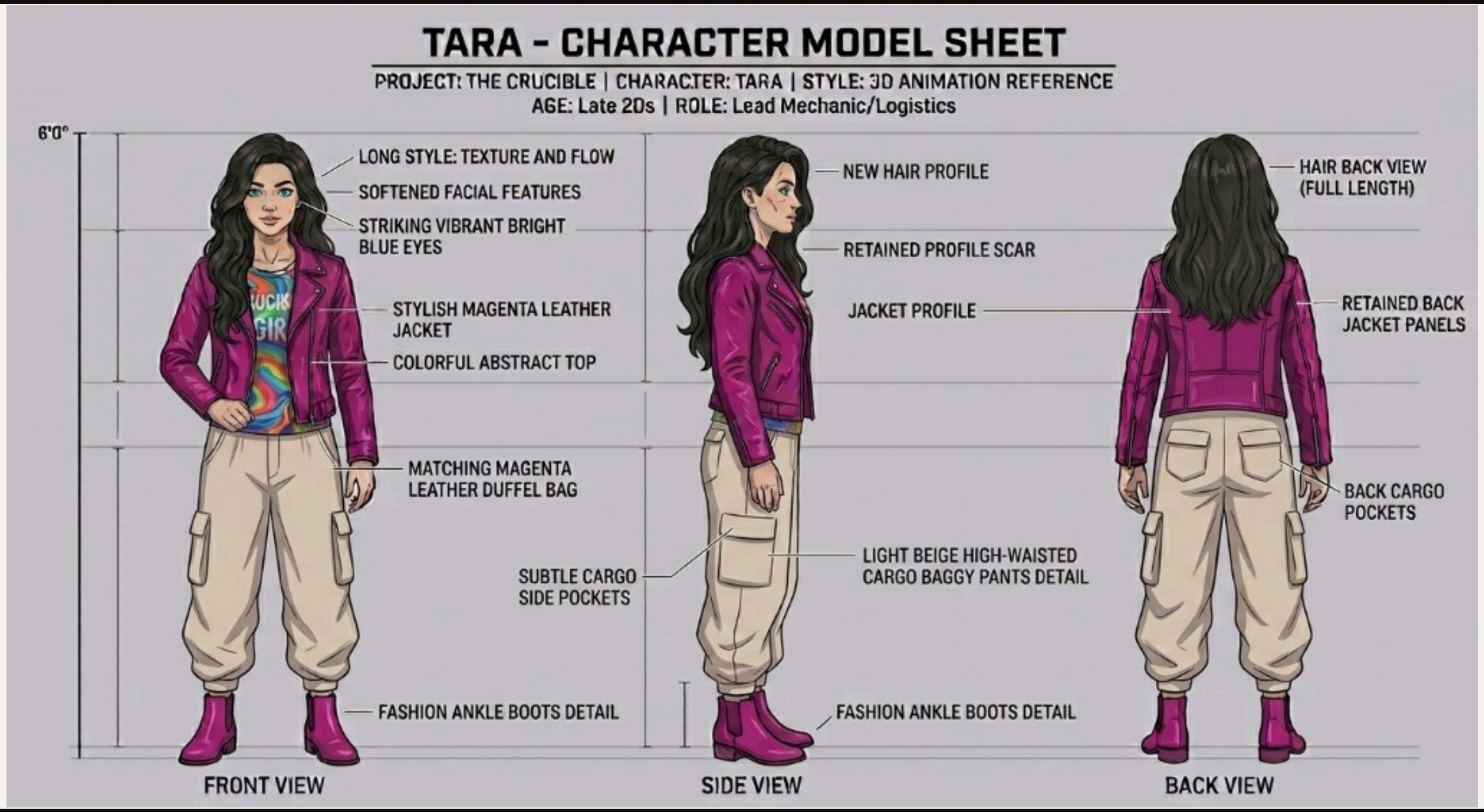


THE CHAMELEON

MEI

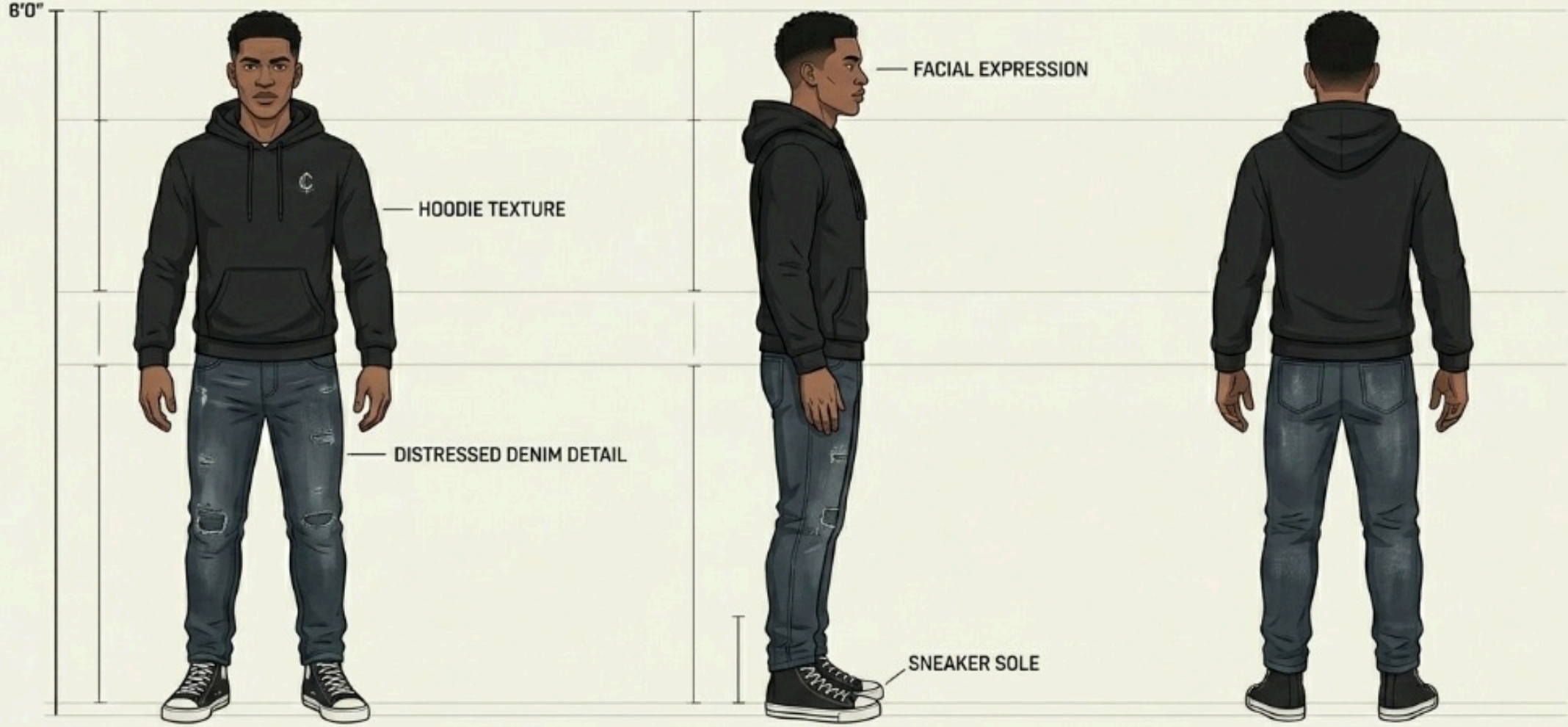
Projects vulnerability hiding a predatory edge. Weaponizes victimhood until outmaneuvered in Trial 3.

"Sorry, sister! First come—"


TARA - CHARACTER MODEL SHEET
PROJECT: THE CRUCIBLE | CHARACTER: TARA | STYLE: 3D ANIMATION REFERENCE
AGE: Late 20s | ROLE: Lead Mechanic/Logistics
6'0"
LONG STYLE: TEXTURE AND FLOW
SOFTENED FACIAL FEATURES
STRIKING VIBRANT BRIGHT BLUE EYES
STYLISH MAGENTA LEATHER JACKET
COLORFUL ABSTRACT TOP
MATCHING MAGENTA LEATHER DUFFEL BAG
FASHION ANKLE BOOTS DETAIL
FRONT VIEW
NEW HAIR PROFILE
RETAINED PROFILE SCAR
JACKET PROFILE
SUBTLE CARGO SIDE POCKETS
LIGHT BEIGE HIGH-WAISTED CARGO BAGGY PANTS DETAIL
FASHION ANKLE BOOTS DETAIL
SIDE VIEW
HAIR BACK VIEW (FULL LENGTH)
RETAINED BACK JACKET PANELS
BACK CARGO POCKETS
BACK VIEW

KWAME - CHARACTER MODEL SHEET

PROJECT: THE CRUCIBLE | CHARACTER: KWAME | STYLE: 3D ANIMATION REFERENCE
AGE: Early 20s | HEIGHT: 6'0" | ROLE: Street Operative



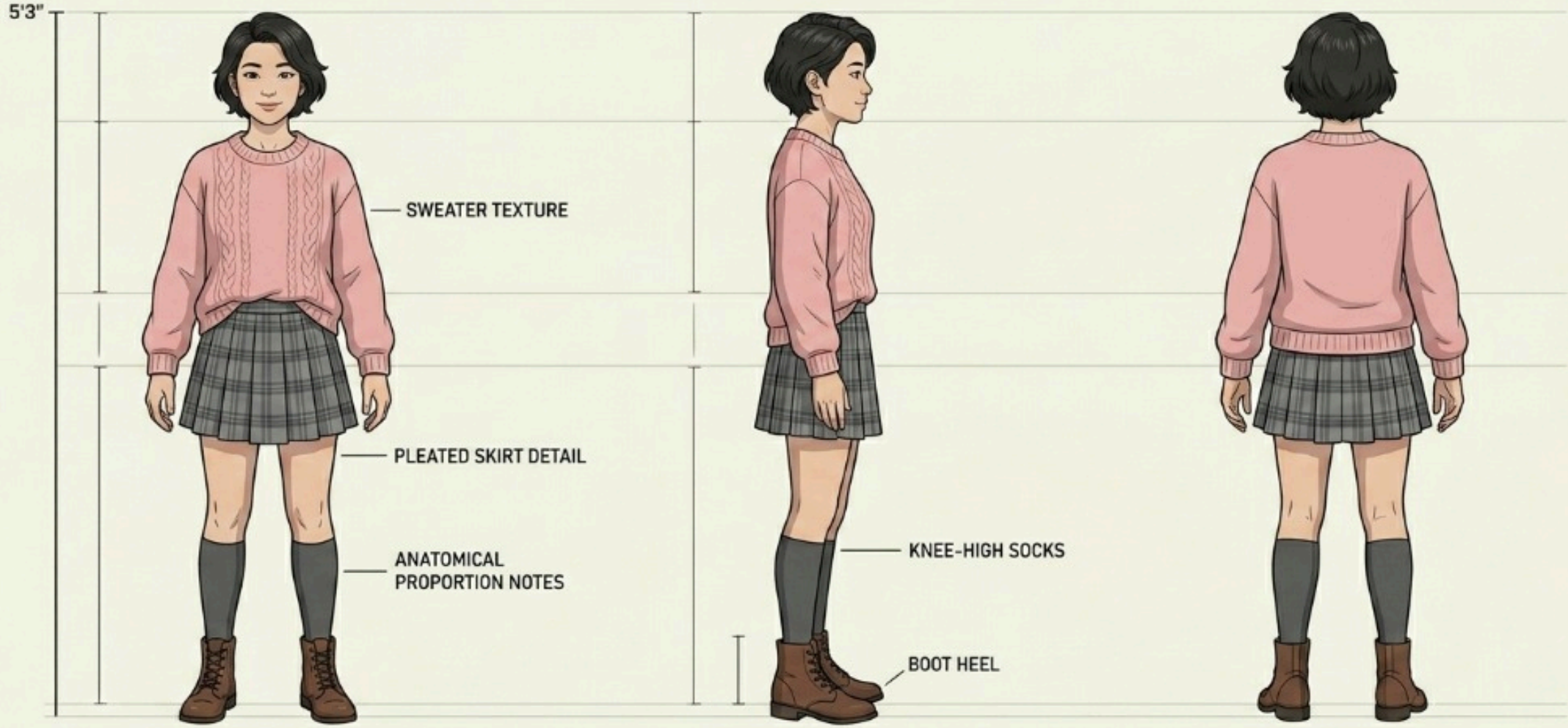
JAMES - CHARACTER MODEL SHEET

PROJECT: THE CRUCIBLE | CHARACTER: JAMES | STYLE: 3D ANIMATION REFERENCE
AGE: Late 20s | HEIGHT: 6'0" | ROLE: Analyst (Casual Reference)



MEI - CHARACTER MODEL SHEET

PROJECT: THE CRUCIBLE | CHARACTER: MEI | STYLE: 3D ANIMATION REFERENCE
AGE: Early 20s | ROLE: Delicate/Soft-spoken



THE THREE TRIALS

Each Trial Strips Away a Human Defense

TRIAL ONE

01

Sacrifice



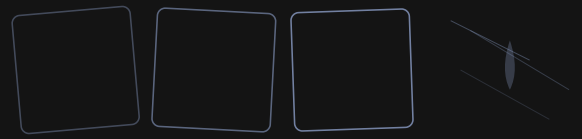
A biometric circuit requires all four conduits in sync. Kwame breaks rank, suspecting a trap. The floor opens beneath him into incinerating plasma.

→ KWAME ELIMINATED

TRIAL TWO

02

Exposure



Neural probes project childhood trauma as holographic memories. James collapses under the truth that his mother's love was commercially contracted.

→ JAMES ELIMINATED

TRIAL THREE

03

Sleight of Hand



One crystalline extraction key. Mei feigns sisterly unity while hiding a carbon-fiber stylus. Tara anticipates the ambush and claims the key.

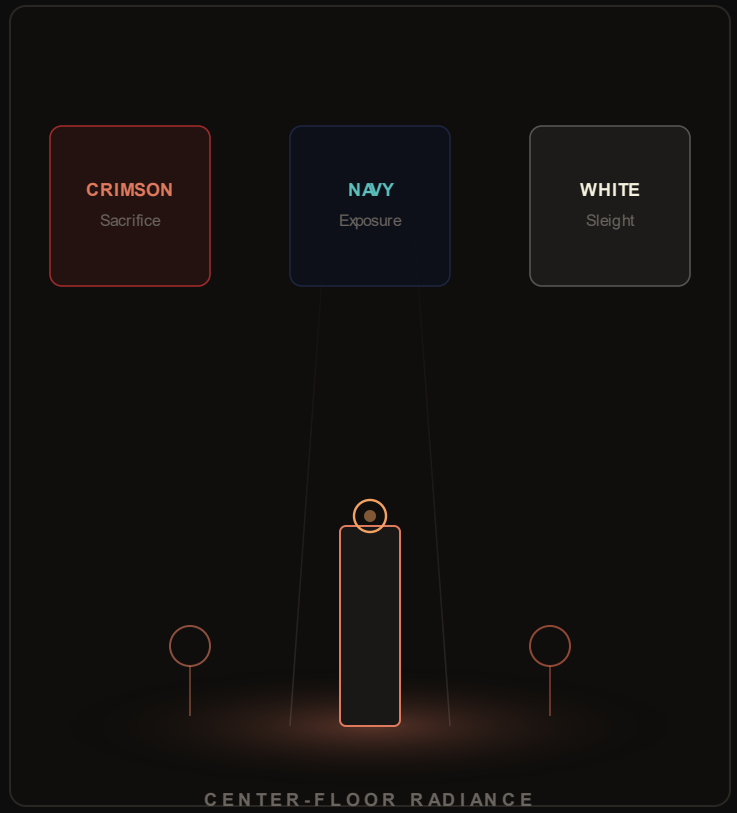
→ MEI ELIMINATED · TARA ASCENDS

The Environment Is the Antagonist

The Crucible Chamber shifts its real-time lighting, color temperature, and volumetric atmosphere to psychologically pressure the subjects. Each trial triggers a distinct chromatic signature.

STARK WHITE	CRIMSON	DEEP NAVY	GOLDEN HOUR
The Void / Awakening	Trial 1: Sacrifice	Trial 2: Exposure	Penthouse Summit

Lumen GI — Zero baked lightmaps; real-time bounce light off matte polymer.
Emissive Floor — Upward volumetric diffusion eliminating overhead down-shadows.
Cine Cameras — Geometric tracking + handheld combat shake.



TECHNICAL PRODUCTION PIPELINE

End-to-End Unreal Engine 5 Workflow

MetaHuman + Maya — Marvelous Designer — Maya Rigging — UE5 Lumen + Nanite — Niagara VFX — MRQ + DaVinci

PHASE	SOFTWARE & FRAMEWORKS	DELIVERABLES
Character Sculpting	MetaHuman Creator & Autodesk Maya	Custom facial blendshapes, MetaHuman DNA rig, topology refinement, and head/body sculpts.
Costume & Garments	Marvelous Designer & Maya	3D garment patterning, dynamic jumpsuit cloth simulation, retopology, and UV cleanup.
Rigging & Animation	Maya & UE5 Control Rig	Live Link facial capture, full-body keyframe animation, Chaos cloth physics setup.
Environment Design	Unreal Engine 5 (Nanite)	Modular void chamber, high-density Nanite meshes, procedural architecture, seamless seals.
Lighting & Atmosphere	UE5 Lumen & Volumetrics	Real-time GI, emissive floor bounce, volumetric fog, dynamic color-shift per trial.
VFX & Dynamic Systems	UE5 Niagara	High-voltage electrical arcs, plasma incinerator, holographic memory projections.
Render & Post	Movie Render Queue & DaVinci Resolve	Multi-pass EXR output, ACES color grading, chromatic aberration, audio mastering.

CHARACTER CREATION PIPELINE

MetaHuman to Final Performance

STAGE 1 — BASE GENERATION

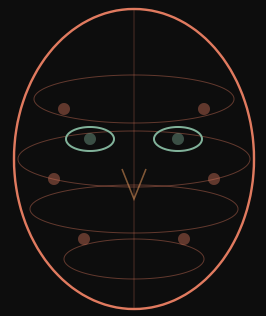
High-fidelity MetaHuman base generation with custom facial sculpts. Each heir receives unique facial topology refined in Autodesk Maya for distinct silhouette recognition.

STAGE 2 — COSTUME FABRICATION

Identical slate-grey utilitarian jumpsuits designed in Marvelous Designer. Mei's costume features hidden compartments for weapon concealment. Dynamic cloth draping via Chaos physics.

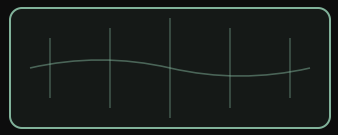
STAGE 3 — PERFORMANCE CAPTURE

MetaHuman DNA facial rig with Live Link integration. Expressive micro-facial animations for extreme close-ups. Full-body Control Rig keyframe animation with athletic kinetic profiles.



METAHUMAN DNA RIG

Custom Blendshape Topology



MARVELOUS DESIGNER

Dynamic Cloth Patterns

UNREAL ENGINE 5

CORE THEMES & AUDIENCE

Why CRUCIBLE Resonates Now

In an era of hyper-capitalist inheritance anxiety and generational divide, CRUCIBLE distills succession pressure into a claustrophobic, visually stunning sci-fi parable.

GENERATIONAL TRAUMA

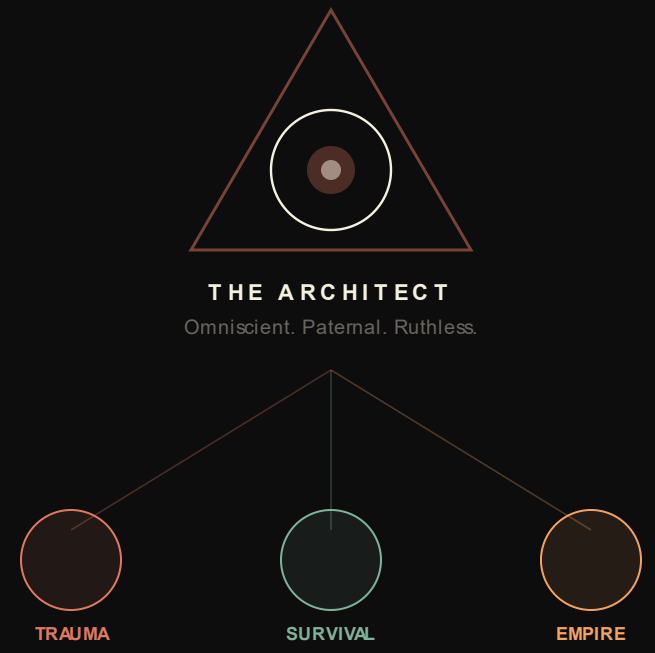
Four half-siblings, abandoned by the same billionaire patriarch, discover their entire lives were experiments in selection pressure.

RUTHLESS PRAGMATISM VS. VULNERABILITY

Each trial rewards cold calculation and punishes emotional connection—mirroring hyper-capitalist selection mechanisms.

HYPER-CAPITALIST SUCCESSION

The Architect doesn't seek children—he seeks an apex successor. Love is a liability. Survival is the only credential.



TARGET: AGES 16–35 · STREAMING · FESTIVAL

COMPLETE SCREENPLAY



CRUCIBLE

Screenplay

SCI-FI PSYCHOLOGICAL THRILLER · 3D ANIMATED SHORT FILM

Screenplay — Act I: The Awakening

INT. CRUCIBLE CHAMBER - DAY (?)

Absolute void. Pure, sterile, blinding white. No seams. No corners. No visible fixtures or fixtures of shadow. An endless cube illuminated by an ambient, omnidirectional white radiance that seemingly emits from the exact center of the floor.

Lying sprawled across the immaculate floor are four figures dressed in identical, utilitarian slate-grey attire.

TARA blinks, squinting fiercely against the glare. She groans, pushing herself up with one hand while rubbing her temples. She looks straight down at the glowing floor beneath her palms, then cranes her neck upward into the limitless void.

TARA

Great. I died and ended up inside a giant fluorescent lightbulb.

She kicks the seamless floor lightly with the toe of her boot.

TARA (CONT'D)

Seriously, where the hell is the light even coming from? Center stage, but zero fixtures. Did God hire an aggressively minimalist interior designer?

A few feet away, JAMES stirs. He doesn't complain; his eyes immediately dart across the perimeter, scanning the non-existent walls. He touches the ground, checking texture, temperature, acoustic resonance.

JAMES

No seams. Matte polymer finish. Ambient dispersion without focal heat... This isn't an afterlife, it's an engineered enclosure. High-grade synthetic containment.

TARA

Oh, thank heavens. A nerd with a clipboard in his head. I feel safer already.

Nearby, KWAME bolts awake, rolling into a low crouch, fists half-raised, breathing steady. His street instincts immediately take over as he checks his pockets—empty.

KWAME

Pockets picked. Shoes intact. No visible exits, no vents. Keep your backs together. Whoever dumped us here is watching through the walls.

MEI

(Small, trembling voice)

W-where are we...?

MEI sits curled on the floor, clutching her knees to her chest. She looks terrified, wide-eyed, trembling slightly.

MEI (CONT'D)

Please... I was just walking back from my studio. Did someone kidnap us? Is this... for ransom?

KWAME

(Softening slightly, glancing at her)

Stay calm, kid. Don't hyperventilate. Conserve your energy.

JAMES

(Stepping toward Mei)

Nobody panic. Panic creates irrational variables. We assess our parameters, determine the entry vector, and formulate a breach protocol.

TARA

(Crossing her arms, smirking)

Fabulous plan, Captain Spreadsheet. Step one: figure out why the four of us are starring in a monochromatic nightmare.

Suddenly, a deep, resonant, synthetic hum vibrates through the deck. A central pedestal ascends silently from the floor. Atop it sits a glowing, geometric terminal.

Screenplay — Act II: Trial 1 — Sacrifice

The white chamber pulses crimson. Four individual hexagonal biometric pads rise around the central altar. Above the altar, a countdown clock illuminates in stark red digits: 02:00... 01:59...

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

Trial One: Sacrifice. The vessel requires equilibrium. Four conduits must synchronize their physical energy to stabilize the core. Failure to unify before zero results in total atmospheric purge.

Four distinct energy nodes crackle with electrical voltage above each pad.

JAMES

It's a circuit bridge! We have to lock our hands onto the nodes simultaneously to complete the loop and discharge the chamber's kinetic buildup!

TARA

Translation: we hold hands with high-voltage death. Charming.

MEI

(Trembling)

I can't... the voltage will kill us!

JAMES

It will distribute evenly if all four of us hold on! One, two, three—now!

Tara, James, and Mei grip the nodes. An intense violet arc surges through their bodies. They scream in agonizing strain as their biometric gauges slowly rise toward stabilization.

Kwame hesitates, his boots inches from his terminal. He sees the violent arcs tearing through them. His internal survival calculus goes into overdrive.

KWAME

No way. You're draining yourselves to zero. As soon as we tap out, whatever's running this place will finish us off while we're unconscious! I'm finding another way out!

Kwame turns and sprints toward the perimeter, slamming his fists against the boundary wall, seeking a hidden seam or sensor latch.

TARA

(Straining through gritted teeth)

Kwame! You selfish idiot... get on the damn pad!

JAMES

The loop isn't closed! Feedback surge in ten seconds! Kwame!

The countdown hits 00:05... 00:04... The floor beneath Kwame turns instantly translucent, revealing a swirling, incinerating plasma vent below.

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

Deficit detected. Non-compliant element rejected.

KWAME

Wait—!

The floor drops. Kwame plunges into the plasma void. A blinding flash of light—and he is gone.

The remaining voltage instantly equalizes across Tara, James, and Mei. The timer stops at 00:00. The pedestals sink back into the floor.

Tara collapses to her knees, panting and coughing. James clutches his burned hands, staring at the empty space where Kwame stood. Mei weeps quietly.

Screenplay — Act III: The Patriarch's Reveal

The room dims to a subdued charcoal gray. A 24-hour rest cycle indicator begins ticking on the ceiling.

MEI

(Shaking, wiping away tears)

He's... he's really dead. He just disappeared...

TARA

He thought he was smarter than the game. Rule number one of death rooms: don't play the lone hero.

The center of the floor shifts. Holographic projections shimmer to life, displaying four childhood medical files, genetic markers, and matching chromosomal sequences.

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

One discarded. Three remaining. You wonder why you four share this crucible. Look upon your origin.

The strands of DNA align into a single golden sequence labeled: PATRIARCH LINEAGE - DIRECT HEIRS.

JAMES

(Staring in utter shock)

A single patriarchal progenitor... That's impossible. We have different mothers, different cities...

TARA

(A bitter, hollow laugh)

Well, well, well. Daddy wasn't just a deadbeat who skipped out on child support. He's an eccentric supervillain with a god complex.

MEI

(Eyes wide with artificial innocence)

We're... brothers and sisters? He put his own children here to die?

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

I do not seek children. I seek an apex successor. Rest. Tomorrow tests the mind.

ACT IV: TRIAL 2 — EXPOSURE

The rest period concludes. The chamber transitions into a suffocating, deep navy hue.

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

Trial Two: Exposure. The mind that hides behind logic and denial is fragile. Face the truth of your abandonment, or shatter under its weight.

The walls begin projecting hyper-realistic memory fragments around them:

A young Tara sitting alone on a rainy stoop on her tenth birthday, blowing out a single candle on a soggy cupcake.

A young Mei locked in an austere dance studio, practicing until her feet bleed under harsh parental demands.

A teenage James sitting in an empty auditorium, clutching a valedictorian medal, waiting for a father who never arrived.

Screenplay — Act IV (Cont.) & Act V: Ascension

James stares at the projection of his younger self. The holographic father turns his back and dissolves into static.

JAMES

(Breath hitching, voice cracking)

I did everything right. Perfect marks. Perfect record. I built systems to ensure zero failure... so he would notice. So he would come back...

TARA

James, snap out of it! It's a psychological playback! He's feeding on your trauma! Don't engage!

JAMES

(Gripping his head, stepping backward)

All of it... completely meaningless. I was never a son. I was an experiment. An uncatalogued specimen...

James's neural bio-feed spikes into red. His logical facade collapses into total emotional despair. The floor tiles beneath James glow deep amber and slide backward.

MEI

James! Grab my hand!

Mei reaches out, but visibly hesitates, keeping her weight safely anchored away from the ledge.

James looks down into the infinite abyss, completely drained of the will to fight.

JAMES

There was never an equation... where we won.

He falls backward, swallowed by the dark void below. The floor seals shut seamlessly behind him.

ACT V: TRIAL 3 — SLEIGHT OF HAND

The chamber turns brilliant, blinding pure white once more. Only Tara and Mei remain. From the dead center of the room, a sleek, solitary pedestal rises. Atop it rests a singular, glowing, crystalline EXTRACTION KEY.

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

Trial Three: Sleight of Hand. One key. One exit. One heir to claim the empire. Only ruthless resolve unlocks the ascension gate.

A glowing gate manifests on the far wall. The pedestal begins a slow 60-second descent back into the floor.

Mei stands across from Tara, her eyes wide, tears brimming.

MEI

(Soft, desperate)

Tara... please. We're sisters. We don't have to play by his rules. If we both hold the key together, maybe we can force the gate open. We can beat him together.

Screenplay — The Finale: Ascension

TARA

(Unmoving, eyes locked on Mei)

You really want to team up, little sister?

MEI

Yes! I don't want to hurt you. I'm scared. Let's just walk up together.

Mei takes slow, cautious steps toward the pedestal, hands open in a universal gesture of peace.

Tara watches her feet. She notices Mei's right sleeve cuff subtly pulled back, concealing a sharpened carbon-fiber stylus she palmed from the previous console.

As Mei reaches the pedestal, her innocent expression vanishes in an instant. A cold, predatory smirk cuts across her face.

She lunges with blinding speed, snatching the key with her left hand while driving the concealed stylus straight toward Tara's throat!

MEI

Sorry, sister! First come, first—

CRACK!

Tara doesn't flinch. Having anticipated the deceit, she side-steps the thrust, catches Mei's wrist, and twists it violently downward, disarming her.

In one fluid, merciless motion, Tara sweeps Mei's legs out from under her. Mei crashes hard onto the descending pedestal platform.

Tara snatches the extraction key right out of Mei's open hand.

TARA

(Cold, devoid of sarcasm)

Innocent eyes. Shaky hands. Cheap trick up your sleeve. You played the victim very well, Mei. But you forgot one thing.

MEI

(Panicking, thrashing against the sinking floor)

Tara! Wait! Please! I was scared—!

TARA

I grew up in the same family.

Tara steps off the pedestal just as it locks into the floor and seals shut, leaving Mei trapped on the lower decompression level as the seal turns opaque.

The chamber falls silent.

The far ascension gate slides open with a heavy, pressurized hiss, revealing a sleek, golden executive elevator overlooking a vast, sprawling futuristic metropolis below.

THE ARCHITECT (V.O.)

Perception sharp. Sentiment discarded. Resolve absolute. Welcome to the summit, my daughter. The Crucible has tempered its master.

Tara looks down at the crystalline extraction key in her palm. Her expression is hard, unyielding, and completely detached.

She turns her back on the empty, seamless white chamber, steps through the gate, and enters the elevator.

The doors slide shut.

FADE TO BLACK.

CRUCIBLE

"Inheritance demands everything."

3D ANIMATED CINEMATIC SHORT · UNREAL ENGINE 5

SCI-FI PSYCHOLOGICAL THRILLER · 8–12 MINUTES

READY FOR PRODUCTION